From the Flow

by Janet O'Neill

INTRODUCTION

What I should have said: *Suicide is not chosen; it happens when pain exceeds resources for coping with pain. That's all it's about. You are not a bad person, or crazy, or weak, or flawed because you feel suicidal. It doesn't even mean that you really* ***want*** *to die – it only means that you have more pain than you can cope with* ***right now****. There are people out there (I'm one of them) who can be with you in this horrible time, and will not judge you, or argue with you, or send you to a hospital, or try to talk you out of how badly you feel. They will . . .* ***I will*** *simply care for you. I'm here . . . let me help.*

What I did say: *Keep the pen flowing. Never drop the pen . . . Just flow.*

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TEACHER: **(Pg 63-65)** Welcome to my home away from home. Room 316. Parkside High. For thirteen years I have taught English composition to teens. Show them their voice. Help find their voice in print. I read a lot of Peter Elbow, who postulates that if you help someone find their voice, as a teacher, you are an educational success. So that's what I do; I develop voices. They write daily journals and that gives me the chance to delve into what makes teenagers tick. One writes of an impending pom squad tryout, another about their love of Nascar. One day, one writes, ***"Sometimes I wish the world would leave me alone. Or that I could leave it alone."*** My inquisitive mind reels. Am I reading too much into it?

Journals develop voices. That's a fact. When I was sixteen, my English teacher made us write ten minutes a day. No subject. No "daily topic." And confidential -- no telling the parents anything! The only objective was to keep the pen flowing. ***Never drop the pen***, he announced. ***Just flow.***

His name is Dean Aiken and his journal has become my Friday obsession. Once a week, the students stack their notebooks under the chalkboard and I quickly race to Dean's writings first as soon as the bell rings. While others are talking about how the cafeteria

food needs improvement, Dean writes in the abstract. He's a junior but hasn't made varsity baseball yet. He doesn't like that. He doesn't like having to take the bus to school. His parents used to take him. His writings were the same, yet constantly differing. Altering from the glass being half full to half empty. ***Why can't they just leave me alone?*** he'd write. "They" could be anyone. "They" were anyone.

Just flow. So I wrote. I told my teacher about how students told me I was a lesbian because of the way I dressed. Told him about how Tim Robertson always calls me a slut if I don't let him copy off my paper. Told him about how I felt sitting alone in the cafeteria for lunch until a teacher sat with me. It helped. And he helped, too. One day, we got a seating chart. Tim was seated in the opposite corner from me. It was only a seating chart, but it was a signal. He was helping me.

Dean's writing became erratic. Days would be skipped completely. Lines would be erased. I felt like some sort of voyeur trying to uncover the mystery of what he'd erased. Then he wrote: ***My granddad had it tough. He worked at a coal mine 6 to 6. But God helped him. He's resting at the cemetery next to a beautiful tree. He can sleep when he wants. Get up when he wants. He must like that. I know I will.*** Not "would," but "will." My God, I thought. Does this child really want to die? I slipped a card for a local youth center into his journal. Maybe he'll go, I thought. He has to go.

People think I'm weird, he'd write, ***but they just don't know what's going down.*** The messages became blatant cries. ***I have nowhere to go.*** I kept him after class to discuss things. ***What things?*** He'd say. We'd stare at each other and fifteen minutes later, he'd leave with a pass. ***Sorry to waste your time.*** My teacher solved it with a seating chart. I can do this. I can.

My mind raced. ***What should I do??*** I can't tell his parents -- that's the whole point of the journals. It's a secret. But they should know. Could I tell the principal? That'd be worse. He's not even family. Besides, he hasn't actually said he's suicidal, right?

The classes are called to the auditorium over the intercom. The principal steps to the

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microphone. He announces that a student at our school, Dean Aiken, has died from a fatal gunshot wound to the head. I pinch myself. ***Wake up! I said. Wake up!*** But there I was. In an auditorium filled with now-mourning people, apparently the only one who saw it coming. And the only one that did nothing about it. Newspapers ran stories that night, denouncing his father for keeping a gun in the house. Part of me wanted to blame him. I needed someone to share the blame.

Class was canceled for the funeral. Dean has a lot of friends. I could have helped. I could have told. How bad could it have been? I could have done something. Instead, I'd told him to flow.

When his mother asked for a meeting, I was not shocked. She had gathered his belongings from his locker and scoured over them undoubtedly. I would have done it, too. *(the conversation echoes in her memory)*

MOTHER: Do you read these journals??

TEACHER: *Yes. Yes I do. Every Friday.*

MOTHER: Then explain to me why you passed Dean's over.

TEACHER: *I didn't. I read it.*

MOTHER: Well, if you read it you would have known! We all would have known!

TEACHER: *I knew . . . I knew.*

MOTHER: Then why. Why!!

TEACHER: *I don't know. See, the journals are confidential –*

MOTHER: Damn you! He came to you. I don't know why he came to you, but he did. You chose to sit there.

TEACHER: *No -- I kept him after class –*

MOTHER: You call yourself a teacher. You murdered him.

TEACHER: *I know, I know. Please forgive me. (to audience)* Only I knew I wasn't just asking forgiveness from her. I was asking God as well.

TEACHER: I open my journal and write the events of the day. Usually, I write of achievements.

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Accomplishments at the job. At home. With my family. Today, I write of being accused of murder. Today I write without having a response. I write to escape. I write to release. I write out of habit.

Just flow, I think. Just flow.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Janet O'Neill
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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier - MS
2021 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier – MS
2023 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

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